From there Peres entered the Knesset as a member of Mapai, the forerunner of the Labor party. He shuttled between various cabinet posts until 1974, when Rabin named him defense minister, a position that allowed Peres to play another fateful role in his country's history.

The settler population grew slowly in the first few years after the 1967 war, because the government was unwilling to approve major construction. Around the time Peres entered the defense ministry, a prominent right-wing activist named Yehuda Etzion decided to create facts on the ground. He secured a contract to build a fence around a military base near Ofra, northeast of Ramallah, and brought a group of would-be settlers (a "work brigade") with him. After eight months on the site, they decided to start sleeping there overnight, the first step toward establishing a community. "They were sent hints that Defense Minister Shimon Peres was looking for a way to approve their settlements in the area," two Israeli writers would later recount. "If they made their move quietly and without publicity, and the settlement was called a 'work camp', with no mention of a permanent 'settlement', there was a chance that they would be allowed to stay."[20]

So they did. One day in April 1975, after their shifts ended, the settlers moved into a group of abandoned buildings, the remnants of a Jordanian military camp. Peres ordered their removal. Then he reversed himself, wondering how he could direct the army "at nine or ten at night to evacuate them by force."[21] Rabin eventually legalized the settlement. Some of the settlers, including Etzion, live there to this day. (He would later join the Jewish Underground, and was jailed in 1984 for plotting to bomb the Dome of the Rock.)

The hawkish Peres saw the settlements as a key part of Israel's security, helping to "fortify Jerusalem… and establish the Jordan River as our security border," he wrote in his 1978 book, *Tomorrow Is Now*. He wasn't worried that a Jewish presence in the West Bank would foreclose the possibility of a Palestinian state. He didn't think one possible. "Maybe this Arab generation cannot live in harmony and peace with Israel," he wrote. "Perhaps this Arab generation can agree only to some interim arrangement, but the arrangement should not involve a withdrawal to the 1967 borders, nor the establishment of a Palestinian state."[22]

Volte-face